

An abstract painting featuring a central figure with large, circular, blue-rimmed eyes. The figure's body is composed of various textures and colors, including dark, light, and vibrant hues. The background is a complex mix of brushstrokes and layered colors, creating a sense of depth and movement. The overall style is expressive and contemporary.

blessed by the **bees**
a solo exhibition by **ZAKES MDA**

SPRINGS ART GALLERY
20th June – 31st July 2026

(SAG)

Curatorial Statement

Blessed by the bees | a solo exhibition by Profe Selecting works for this exhibition was both an honour and a demanding curatorial undertaking. The sheer volume and richness of the work produced by Zakes Mda, housed in his studio in Rosebank, offer an abundance that could easily overwhelm any attempt at restraint. Each piece carries its own narrative weight, making the act of selection an exercise in careful distillation rather than exclusion.

Blessed by the Bees, as a title, finds poetic and conceptual resonance within Mda's lifelong community work. For those familiar with his life and practice, the reference to bees is neither incidental nor decorative – it speaks directly to his longstanding commitment to beekeeping in the Eastern Cape, an activity that exists in parallel with his artistic and intellectual pursuits. Here, the bee becomes both a metaphor and a method, symbolising labour, community, discipline, and the delicate balance between creation and vulnerability.

Several works in the exhibition, including the featured image on the exhibition poster, reveal recurring self-portraits situated across varied environments. These visual reflections render the exhibition deeply autobiographical, positioning Mda not only as a creator, but also a subject. Through these shifting self-representations, the viewer encounters a layered identity, one that traverses geography, memory, and imagination.

The colourful palette that defines much of the work echoes Mda's literary sensibilities. Much like his storytelling, the compositions are vivid, textured, and immersive. Each frame operates as a narrative portal, inviting the viewer into a world where visual and literary languages converge. Subtle insertions of bees here, and hives there, function as both motif and signal, suggesting an impending sensory encounter, a "sting" that is as aesthetic as it is intellectual.

What is particularly striking about Mda's creative output is his refusal to be confined. He challenges the compartmentalisation often imposed by disciplinary boundaries. Instead, he embraces a holistic creative identity, one that fluidly navigates scholarship, theatre, literature, music, and visual art. As a scholar, playwright, novelist, and composer, Mda brings a rare interdisciplinary depth to his visual practice. His work ultimately dares the viewer to reconsider the limits of artistic categorisation, reminding us of that creativity, like the hive, thrives in multiplicity and interconnectedness.

The Blessed by the Bees art exhibition explores themes of familiarity and estrangement that have marked Zakes Mda's work over recent years, heavily featuring motifs of memory, imagination, and presence in a psyche's effort to locate itself in place and time.

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Artist in Recline

Mixed media on canvas
48 x 36in (stretched)
2026

R100 000.00

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Community

Mixed media on canvas

112 x 91cm

2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**
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Hornman in meditation

Mixed media on canvas

112 x 91cm

2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**

a solo exhibition by **ZAKES MDA**



Indlela esihambayo
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**
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Artist in meditation II
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**
a solo exhibition by **ZAKES MDA**



Artist in meditation
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

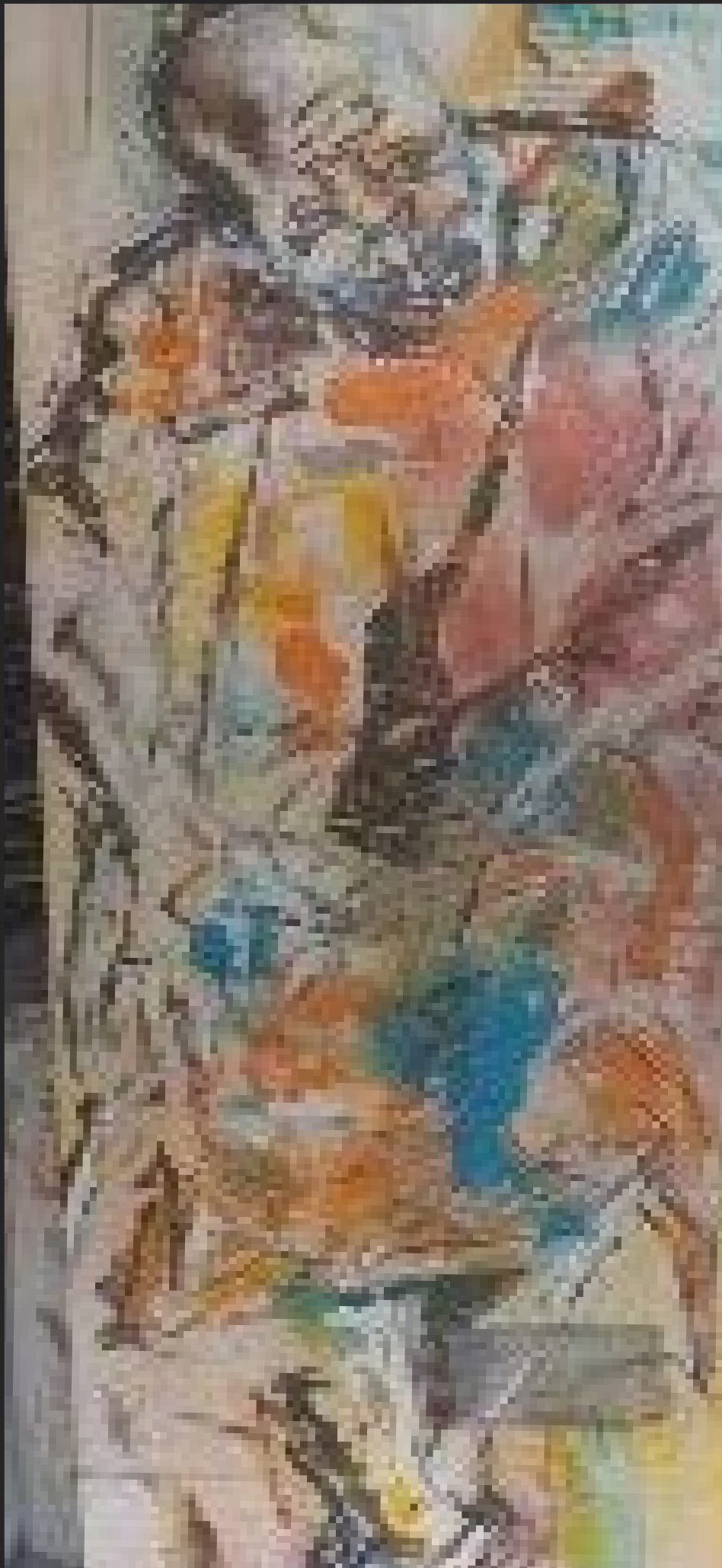
blessed by the **bees**
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The hornman
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**
a solo exhibition by **ZAKES MDA**



Untitled
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

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Blessed by the bees
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

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Jazz in Seoia I
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

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So sorry
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

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Granddaughter
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**
a solo exhibition by **ZAKES MDA**



Racing to the sun

Mixed media on canvas

112 x 91cm

2026

R100 000.00

blessed by the **bees**

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Maqoma (Diptych)
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00

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Hughie
Mixed media on canvas
112 x 91cm
2026

R100 000.00